

M. Merritt Smith

PHD STUDENT · UC BERKELEY SCHOOL OF INFORMATION

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Research Statement

I study what data, models, and methods can credibly tell us about the lives of poor and vulnerable populations. Active projects measure agricultural management intensity from satellite imagery, decompose the welfare-predictive signal in mobile-phone records, track poverty dynamics and shock incidence in a longitudinal Malawi household panel, and evaluate the use of large language models in poverty targeting.

Education

University of California Berkeley

PHD INFORMATION

- Coursework in development economics, econometrics, machine learning

Berkeley, CA

2024-present

University of Chicago

MS COMPUTATIONAL ANALYSIS AND PUBLIC POLICY

- Coursework in computer science, statistics, econometrics, machine learning

Hyde Park, IL

2020 - 2022

Tufts University

BA DATA SCIENCE AND PUBLIC POLICY

- Coursework in philosophy, computer science, statistics, mathematics, econometrics, machine learning
- Studied abroad in General Course at LSE

Somerville, MA

2014 - 2018

Research Experience

Global Opportunities Lab, UC Berkeley School of Information

ADVISOR: JOSHUA BLUMENSTOCK

- Conducting research with the World Bank to understand the limits of prediction with phone detail records
- Contributing to an ongoing longitudinal study of poverty in Malawi

Berkeley, CA

2024-present

Crime Lab / Center for Applied Artificial Intelligence, University of Chicago

CO-SUPERVISORS: DR. JENS LUDWIG, DR. SENDHIL MULLAINATHAN

- Developed computer vision models using a transfer learning framework for a project aimed at increasing DV reporting in hospitals using computer vision on X-rays
- Conducted analyses of New York, Chicago, Indianapolis, and Philadelphia police complaints for forthcoming paper on early intervention systems for officer misconduct

Hyde Park, IL

2022 - 2024

Centre for Economic Performance, London School of Economics

SUPERVISOR: DR. JEFFREY GROGGER

- Developed propensity score models to estimate ATE of multiple treatments
- Calculated CATEs using Athey & Wager's causal forests methodology
- Eliminated technical debt by building R / Stata pipeline

Remote

2022

Manuseto Intitute for Urban Innovation, University of Chicago

SUPERVISOR: DR. LUÍS BETTENCOURT

- Developed building- and block-level population estimates for every building in sub-Saharan Africa using geospatial Python
- Assisted in the calculation of network-theoretic measures of urban informality

Hyde Park, IL

2020-2022

- Undergraduate Honors Thesis, High Honors: "Understanding Intranational Wealth Inequality, a Machine Learning Approach"

Publications

PUBLISHED

M. Merritt Smith, Emily Aiken, Joshua E. Blumenstock, Sveta Milusheva. 2026. Predicting Well-Being with Mobile Phone Data: Evidence from Four Countries. American Economic Association Papers & Proceedings

WORKING PAPERS

Generated Data, Real Consequences: Why LLMs Are Inappropriate for Development Aid Targeting

RESEARCH ASSISTANCE

Black, Dan A., et al. Criminal charges, risk assessment, and violent recidivism in cases of domestic abuse. No. w30884. National Bureau of Economic Research, 2023.

Bettencourt, Luís, and Nicholas Marchio. "Street access, Informality and Development: A block level analysis across all of sub-Saharan Africa." arXiv preprint arXiv:2307.16328 (2023).

Bettencourt, Luís MA, and Nicholas Marchio. "Infrastructure deficits and informal settlements in sub-Saharan Africa." Nature (2025): 1-8.

Awards, Fellowships, & Grants

2025 **Hal Varian Fellowship**, UC Berkeley School of Information

Presentations

INVITED TALKS

Spring 2020. *Change the Rules, Break the Game*. Invited talk: OECD 2020 Anti-Corruption and Integrity Forum (cancelled due to COVID-19), Paris, FR.

Teaching Experience

Fall 2026 **INFO 241: Experiments and Causal Inference**, Teaching Assistant

Fall 2023 **Artificial Intelligence for Public Policy**, Teaching Assistant

Winter
2022 **Artificial Intelligence for Public Policy**, Teaching Assistant

Winter
2021 **Data and Programming for Public Policy 2**, Teaching Assistant

Fall 2020 **Data and Programming for Public Policy 2**, Teaching Assistant

Professional Experience

United States Census Bureau

Remote

DATA SCIENCE FELLOW / CIVIC DIGITAL FELLOW

2021

- Built predictive algorithm to determine the most likely port of exit for shipments of goods leaving the United States for the Department of Transportation
- Replaced a GUI tool that required 5 years of person-hours with a model that requires 10 hours of upkeep/ year
- Selected as part of Civic Digital Fellows program, with a 6% acceptance rate

TRACE International

Annapolis, MD

RESEARCH ASSOCIATE

2018-2020

- Developed methodology for understanding country-level corruption now used by hundreds of multinational organizations for bribery risk assessment
- Built a first-in-industry anomaly detection model using Isolation Forests with Dask for parallelized computation now used in every TRACE due diligence report
- Created agent-based models of bribery using Q-learning agents
- Built neural machine translation models to translate between 9 different languages and English

Certifications _____

2025 CITI, Human subjects research ethics training

Programming Languages and Software _____



Extracurricular Activities _____

Reading, triathlon, bikepacking, animal cognition research, piano